



AN AMERICAN flag hangs upside down from El Capitan near Horsetail Fall in Yosemite National Park on Saturday as part of a protest. TRACY BARBUTES San Francisco Chronicle

Plan to cut park workers reversed

After public outcry, administration gives OK for hiring of seasonal employees.

By JACK DOLAN

After a loud public outcry about job cuts at the National Park Service — and a relentless media campaign from outdoors enthusiasts across the country — it looks like the Trump administration has reconsidered.

A plan to eliminate thousands of seasonal workers at the beloved federal agency appears to have been reversed.

Last month, prospective seasonal employees — the people who collect the entrance fees, clean the trails and restrooms and help rescue injured hikers — received emails saying their job offers for the 2025 season had been rescinded.

Last week, a memo sent from the Department of the Interior to park service officials said the agency could hire 7,700 seasonal employees this year, up from the roughly 6,300 who have been hired in recent years.

If fully implemented, that would be a notable exception to the governmentwide hiring freeze imposed when the Trump administration clamped down on the federal bureaucracy, threatening to eliminate entire agencies, offering “deferred resignation” to almost all federal workers and firing tens of thousands of career employees.

The reprieve for the parks is “definitely a win,” said Kristen Brengel, senior vice president of government affairs for the nonprofit National Parks Conservation Assn., which obtained a copy of the memo that was shared with The Times.

And it’s a testament to “advocates, park rangers and everyone else who has been shouting from the mountaintop that we need these positions restored,” Brengel said.

The memo addressed only temporary seasonal employees. It said nothing [See **Parks**, A5]

Fire debris protesters stand ground at landfill

Kelly Martino stood in front of the thundering hood of a Freightliner semi-truck hauling waste from the Palisades fire, determined to block it from entering the Calabasas Landfill.

Martino was among the several dozen people who protested at the site last week, concerned that the ash, debris and soil being carted to the landfill might be potentially toxic.

The crowd chanted “Back it up!” and wielded handwritten signs that read “No Toxic Dumping.” As the queue of trucks grew longer, sheriff’s deputies threatened to make arrests if the crowd

Residents of the Calabasas and Granada Hills areas worry toxic chemicals could harm children

By TONY BRISCOE

didn’t disperse. The protesters stood their ground.

“All the ash and sludge and debris is going to come here — and that’s not acceptable to us,” said Martino, who lives nearby in Agoura Hills. “And we’re not going to wait for a bunch of kids to get sick in 20 years.”

Similar protests took place Feb. 15 at Calabasas Landfill and on Wednesday in Granada Hills near the Sunshine Canyon Landfill. The protesters say they are concerned that toxic chemicals from the fires could drift into their neighborhoods as airborne dust or leach [See **Landfills**, A5]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

NATASHA DOWNING, left, and Kelly Martino lead residents and supporters down Lost Hills Road on Feb. 15 near the Calabasas Landfill to protest the disposal of Palisades fire debris there.

Lessons from botched warnings in Paradise

Few got evacuation notices, and 85 died in 2018 blaze. Sheriff has since beefed up alert systems.

By JENNY JARVIE

A spark from a malfunctioning transmission line ignited a blaze. Before long, gale-force winds whipped

the flames into a mighty firestorm that tore through the Sierra Nevada foothills at the rate of one football field a second.

By 8 a.m. Nov. 8, 2018, when embers began to rain down on the town of Paradise, Calif., most residents had not been ordered to evacuate — even though an hour and a half had passed since the fire was first reported in a remote wooded area seven miles away.

Many fled before they got

official evacuation warnings or alerts. As thick smoke and orange sparks filled the air, roads out of Paradise became gridlocked. Hundreds abandoned their cars and tried to outrun the fire on foot.

In the end, 85 people died, making the Camp fire the deadliest wildfire in California history.

Six years later, how that Northern California community responded to the botched evacuations offers

lessons for Los Angeles County, where wireless evacuation alerts to western Altadena came nine hours after the Eaton fire broke out. A Times investigation in January found that of the 17 confirmed deaths, all occurred on the west side.

As Butte County’s sheriff, Kory L. Honea was responsible for evacuating people to safety. He was strongly criticized for not acting sooner to alert residents.

[See **Evacuations**, A6]

U.S. aid freeze could be China’s windfall

Experts say America may be ceding global influence to key rival that is gaining clout.

By DIDI TANG

WASHINGTON — President Trump’s restrictions on foreign aid and targeting of a key agency funding programs around the world may be offering an opening to America’s biggest adversary: China.

From the dismantling of the U.S. Agency for International Development to quitting international groups, some of Trump’s “America first” moves have raised concerns among some lawmakers and experts about whether the U.S. is ceding global influence to its rivals, especially at a time when Washington is fretting over Beijing’s growing clout.

Foreign assistance offered the U.S. a source of “soft power” — allowing it to cultivate goodwill, build alliances and counter adversaries in a bid to shore up national security without having to dispatch troops, weapons or other more coercive measures.

In Cambodia, the contrast could not be sharper than China sending \$4.4 million to support demining operations, as Trump halted a \$6.3-million grant from the State Department’s Office of Weapons Removal and Abatement partly meant to clear “U.S.-origin unexploded ordnances as the remnants of war.”

Administration officials say it’s past time to review how America spends money abroad.

Asked whether the U.S. was giving China and Russia an opening for greater global influence, national security advisor Mike Waltz rejected the notion, telling NBC’s “Meet the Press” recently that “all too often, these missions and these programs ... are not in line with strategic U.S. interests like pushing back on China.”

In Panama, the Trump administration got the gov- [See **Aid freeze**, A9]

Warm weather could set records

Temperatures are forecast to be 15 to 20 degrees above normal in the Southland this week. CALIFORNIA, B1

Limits are eased for trans care

Children’s Hospital Los Angeles softens its recent restrictions on hormonal treatment. CALIFORNIA, B3

Timeless singer, chart-topper

Roberta Flack, known for tranquil ballads she described as “scientific soul,” has died at 88. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 77/55. B6

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